

Session 3: Sound as a Biophilic Interaction Modality

Aim. To explore how sound can be intentionally shaped and interacted with as a biophilic design material in indoor environments.



Group 1 - Final sketch of a sonic threshold stair. Introduces water flow, planting, and textured surfaces along stairs to shape sound during ascent and descent. Use temporal tuning and distributed acoustic cues to differentiate zones, guide movement, & mark transitions without visual signage.



Group 2 - Final sketch of an acoustic study & social nook. Introduces foliage, soil, textured surfaces, & small-scale water features to soften reverberation and generate non-repetitive sound. Uses layering and ambient cues to guide movement, support dwelling, & create transitions between social and quieter zones.

Key Outcomes (how explored)

- Sound fields for movement. Sound was imagined as spatially distributed “acoustic fields”, layered and perceptible across distance, that occupants can enter, pass through, linger within, or leave (1, 4).
- Sound structures space. Differences in reverberation, diffusion, and acoustic scale were used to distinguish open from enclosed conditions and foreground from background activity, translating spatial depth into sound (2).
- Sound supports habits & routines. Changes in sound density, intensity, and pattern can communicate information (e.g. time, activity, and environmental state), enabling occupants to learn, interpret, and develop relationships with indoor soundscapes (3).
- Natural quietness replaces acoustic vacuum. Layered, low-arousal soundscapes were used to soften echo & murmur while preserving biophilic textures, re-framing quietness as a healthier alternative to silence (6).

Sessions 1-3 informed the subsequent biophilic design-space mapping, design values and potential human interactions presented in the following sections.